

Racial Representation, Segregation, and Sorting

Jiangnan Zeng*

Abstract: This paper studies the impact of racial representation in local government on individual migration decisions, public goods provision, and residential segregation. By combining individual-level migration data with closely contested mayoral elections, the analysis shows that electing a Black mayor reduces the amenities disparity between majority-Black and white neighborhoods and increases the overall population in majority-Black neighborhoods. The population increase is primarily attributed to decreased out-migration by both Black and white residents. The net effect of these changes is an increase in racial segregation, driven by the greater concentration of Black individuals in majority-Black neighborhoods.

*Department of Economics and Finance, Gordon S. Lang School of Business and Economics, University of Guelph, MacKinnon Bldg, Guelph, Ontario, Canada, N1G 1Y4. (email: jiangnan@uoguelph.ca). I'm grateful to the audiences of numerous seminars and conferences as well as to Randall Walsh, Daniel Jones, Claire Duquenois, Carlos Avenancio, Omer Ali, Patrick Bayer, David Figlio, Evan Mast, Pablo Ernesto Warnes for helpful conversations and feedback.

1 Introduction

Historically, the migration of Black individuals into the central neighborhoods of major U.S. cities occurred alongside a suburbanization trend among white households (Boustan, 2010). However, over the last 50 years, the percentage of Black residents in the 40 most populous central cities has decreased from 40% to 24% (Bartik and Mast, 2022). Major cities that were key hubs during the Great Migration, such as Detroit, Chicago, New York, Atlanta, Dallas, and Los Angeles, have all experienced a decline in their Black demographics (Frey, 2018). As suggested by Bartik and Mast (2022), the decrease in the urban Black population is largely due to the differences in amenities between Black urban neighborhoods and suburban areas. Black households moving to the suburbs generally had higher incomes than those who stayed in the city. In contrast, those who chose to stay, are primarily the economically disadvantaged and the elderly.

On the other hand, the past decades have seen a marked increase in the number of minority elected officials, at all levels of government in the United States. The Voting Rights Act (VRA) of 1965 and its later amendments gave voting rights to African Americans and promoted greater representation of minorities in elected office (Grofman, Handley, and Niemi, 1992). Today, more than one-third of the US’s 100 largest cities are governed by African Americans. However, social and economic racial gaps remain wide. Historically Black neighborhoods in urban areas have suffered from a loss of vitality, leading to a sense of hopelessness and diminishing prospects for improvement. The impact of having Black officials on majority-Black neighborhoods, and the well-being of their constituents remains an open question. Does having a Black leader help reduce racial disparities through fairer public policies and counteract the trend of Black flight? How does minority representation in local government influence the city and affect residents of all racial groups? To explore this, I examine how electing a Black mayor can influence public service provision across neighborhoods, affect the migration decisions of different racial groups both within and between municipalities, and shape segregation patterns in the city.

Using North Carolina voter registration files, I construct an individual-level migration dataset to track voters’ moving decisions both within and across cities and to conduct a heterogeneous analysis across different racial groups and neighborhoods.¹ To causally identify the impact of electing Black mayors, I use a stacked difference-in-differences design, focusing on close mayoral elections between Black and white candidates. I also expand the analysis to 120 major U.S. cities. By utilizing aggregated Census population data at the tract level, I can assess the impact of Black mayors on a larger sample, albeit with less detailed migration data. The main results remain consistent across both samples.

In North Carolina cities, I find that electing Black mayors from closely contested elections leads to a net population increase of 3.9% in majority-Black neighborhoods, 1.2% in diverse neighborhoods

¹I categorize neighborhoods into three types: majority-Black tracts, where Black residents outnumber any other racial group; diverse tracts, where the Black population makes up 30% to 50% of the total; and white tracts, where all racial groups, except whites, comprise less than 30% of the population.

(30%-50% Black share), and 2.5% in white neighborhoods (less than 30% Black share). Over one-third of this net growth across all neighborhood types is driven by individuals relocating from other cities, including a 1.1% increase in Black movers and a 0.8% increase in white movers. Specifically, in majority-Black neighborhoods, electing a Black mayor results in similar net population growth for both Black and white residents, each group increasing by approximately 4%. In neighborhoods with less than 30% Black residents, the impact is more pronounced for Black residents, who experience a 6% increase compared to a 1.7% increase among white residents. These findings are largely consistent when the analysis is extended to 120 major U.S. cities, reflecting nationwide trends.

However, examining population shifts by racial group alone does not fully capture the dynamics at play. Although majority-Black neighborhoods experienced population gains among both Black and white residents, it remains unclear whether these changes reflect gentrification—characterized by affluent newcomers and potential displacement—or simply reduced out-migration, indicating existing residents are choosing to remain. A detailed decomposition of migration patterns reveals that net population growth is primarily driven by declines in out-migration. In majority-Black neighborhoods, the population increases primarily due to reduced outflows among Black and white residents, declining by 5.5% and 4%, respectively. In neighborhoods with fewer than 30% Black residents, growth is driven by a 1.1% increase in white in-migration, combined with reductions in out-migration among both groups. These patterns suggest that the election of a Black mayor primarily benefits existing residents—especially in majority-Black neighborhoods—by encouraging them to stay, pointing toward place-based rather than group-targeted investments as the primary driver of change. This interpretation is further supported by the mechanism analysis.

The substantial increase in Black residents in majority-Black neighborhoods contributes to rising segregation. The analysis shows that the election of a Black mayor leads to a roughly 2% increase in the concentration of Black residents within these neighborhoods, which in turn amplifies city-level segregation by 1% to 1.7%. ²

Digging deeper into the mechanisms, I first show that having a Black mayor improves the amenity conditions in majority-Black neighborhoods using housing price indexes and the entry of polluting facilities across neighborhoods as neighborhood-level amenity measures. Secondly, the presence of a Black mayor redirects public attention towards majority-Black neighborhoods, which in turn brings their issues more prominence in public discourse. Through my data collection from local newspaper coverage in major U.S. cities, I find that Black neighborhoods receive significantly more frequent coverage in local newspapers following the inauguration of a Black mayor. The findings on migration and segregation, along with the mechanism analysis, suggest that place-based interventions are implemented under a Black mayor’s leadership.

This paper contributes to the literature on racial sorting and segregation ([Bayer and McMillan, 2005](#); [Banzhaf and Walsh, 2008](#); [Shertzer and Walsh, 2019](#)). Building upon [Tiebout \(1956\)](#)’s concept

²The increase in segregation is measured by the dissimilarity index: 1% in the North Carolina sample and 1.7% across major U.S. cities.

of individuals “voting with their feet,” this study examines how local political dynamics influence racial sorting and segregation through individual residential decisions. It provides detailed empirical evidence on migration inflows and outflows across neighborhoods and cities, emphasizing how changes in local amenities driven by political outcomes shape residential choices. Additionally, this research enriches the emerging literature on Black flight ([Bartik and Mast, 2022](#); [Baum-Snow and Hartley, 2020](#)), highlighting that increased Black political representation can potentially mitigate Black flight by enhancing the attractiveness of majority-Black neighborhoods in urban areas.

Moreover, this paper addresses the nuanced consequences of investing resources toward majority-Black neighborhoods. It shows that while such policies effectively increase retention within Black communities, they may inadvertently exacerbate overall segregation. Thus, it bridges theoretical and empirical insights into racial inequality and segregation. Specifically, it aligns with theoretical work by [Banzhaf and Walsh \(2013\)](#), which suggests that place-based interventions in minority-dominated communities might unintentionally increase segregation through the return of wealthier minority residents. The findings are also consistent with empirical evidence provided by [Bayer, Fang, and McMillan \(2014\)](#), who demonstrate that the expansion of middle-class Black neighborhoods can similarly reinforce patterns of segregation.

This paper further contributes to the literature on political representation. [Ferrara and Gyourko \(2009\)](#) find that political party affiliation and mayoral gender in the U.S. have limited effects on local outcomes. The evidence regarding the race of local leaders is mixed. [Hopkins and McCabe \(2012\)](#) finds no significant impact on employment or fiscal outcomes from electing minority mayors, whereas other studies suggest minority leadership can reduce racial disparities in public finance, employment, and housing ([Logan, 2020](#); [Beach et al., 2018](#); [Sylvera, 2021](#); [Nye, Rainer, and Stratmann, 2015](#)). However, [Sakong \(2021\)](#) indicates it might reinforce racial biases and widen employment gaps. By employing individual-level data and focusing explicitly on migration decisions—an important yet understudied dimension—this paper provides fresh insights into political representation. Local political leaders can influence residential decisions through discretionary investments in neighborhood amenities, shaping lived experiences and broader patterns of racial inequality and segregation.

Finally, this paper relates to the literature on place-based investment ([Gaubert, Kline, and Yagan, 2021](#); [Kline and Moretti, 2014](#); [Neumark and Simpson, 2015](#)). Place-based policies typically require local government initiation and enforcement. This study highlights the role of Black mayors in reallocating resources, including amenities and media coverage, toward predominantly Black neighborhoods.

The structure of the remaining parts of this paper is organized as follows. Section 2 introduces the institutional context defining the extent of a mayor’s power in the U.S. The third section describes the data utilized and the methodologies adopted in this study. Section 4 presents the primary findings, focusing on North Carolina and other principal cities in the U.S. Following this, Section 5 explores potential alternative mechanisms and discusses prospective implications. Section 6 verifies the robustness of the findings through various checks. The final section, Section 7, offers

a conclusion.

2 Institutional background

Mayoral power in U.S. cities varies significantly depending on a variety of factors including the specific governing structure of the city, the particular powers vested in the mayor by the city's charter, and the political dynamics of the city at any given time. A mayor plays a critical role in shaping neighborhood development through interconnected policies on government spending, taxation, zoning, and fostering private investment. By allocating municipal budgets, mayors decide how much to invest in essential infrastructure, public safety, schools, parks, and other community services—elements that directly enhance neighborhood appeal and quality of life.

Many U.S. cities rely heavily on property taxes, giving mayors influence over tax rates that can shape development incentives. Lower property taxes may attract homeowners and developers, while targeted tax incentives, like Tax Increment Financing (TIF), enable reinvestment into underdeveloped areas. Additionally, mayors can direct subsidies or grants toward priority projects such as affordable housing, business support in low-income neighborhoods, or green energy initiatives, which can stimulate growth in specific areas.

Zoning decisions, often made in collaboration with city councils and planning commissions, also play a key role. Mayors can implement rezoning policies and incentive zoning—such as density bonuses that allow developers to build larger structures if they include affordable housing, green spaces, or other public amenities. Such policies encourage diverse and sustainable neighborhood growth. Mayors can also work with city councils to restrict or prohibit heavy industrial and manufacturing activities in or near residential neighborhoods through specific zoning regulations. By designating industrial zones further from densely populated areas, they can limit residents' exposure to harmful pollutants.

In addition to zoning and spending, mayors can encourage neighborhood development through Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs). These partnerships help cities share costs with private developers for projects like infrastructure, commercial spaces, or housing developments. For instance, by partnering with private developers on mixed-income housing, mayors can address housing needs and stimulate inclusive growth, enhancing the area's economic and social vitality.

Generally, there are two forms of municipal government: Mayor-Council and Council-Manager. Under these two forms, the powers of a mayor can be categorized into two primary types: strong and weak.

In a Mayor-Council form of government, the mayor is elected as an executive leader, separate from the legislative body—i.e., city council. This system can be further divided into two categories: the strong Mayor-Council system and the weak Mayor-Council system. In the strong Mayor-Council system, The mayor has a high degree of control over the administrative and operational aspects of the

city, including budgeting and financial management. She has the authority to veto legislation passed by the city council, and the sole power to appoint individuals to various city government positions, including department heads, without needing approval from the city council. Most major American cities use the strong-mayor form of the mayor-council system (e.g., New York, Houston, Salt Lake City, Minneapolis, Pittsburgh)([Lineberry, Edwards, and Wattenberg, 1983](#); [Svara, 2003](#)). Under the structure of a weak Mayor-Council system, the mayor’s powers are more limited, with the city council holding more legislative and administrative authority. In North Carolina, Mayor-Council remains the principal form of local government (298/533), predominating among cities with populations below 2,500 ([Upshaw, 2014](#)).

Unlike the Mayor-Council system, cities operating under the Council-Manager framework assign the mayor to a role equivalent to other council members. In North Carolina, the majority of cities harboring over 2,500 residents have adopted this governance plan ([Upshaw, 2014](#)). As of 2001, the Council-Manager arrangement was prevalent across 3,302 American cities with a population exceeding 2,500, and 371 counties have embraced this system. It has especially garnered favor in municipalities housing over 10,000 inhabitants, notably in regions spanning the Southeast and the Pacific coast. Within this governance model, Phoenix, Arizona is the most populous city in the nation maintaining a Council-Manager system.

Since the onset of the 21st century, there are also hybrid structures that incorporate features from both Council-Manager and Mayor-Council frameworks, blending elements to suit specific local governance needs. Importantly, in the sample used for this analysis, 80% of the cities are operating under the Mayor-Council form, where the mayor’s role is not just as the visible leader of the city, but also has more power in executive decisions, council voting influence, and the appointment of individuals to key positions.

3 Methods and Data

3.1 Data

3.1.1 Migration data

The individual migration records are constructed based on the Voter Registration file in North Carolina, which is maintained by the North Carolina State Board of Elections and encompasses information on voters registered in North Carolina from 2005 to the present.

The North Carolina voter registration data is sourced from Voter Registration snapshot files. These files offer point-in-time snapshots of information for active voters, inactive voters, and voters removed within the previous decade. Ensuring the data’s accuracy and relevance is an ongoing task. Snapshots are taken periodically, at least twice a year (once on Election Day and once at the beginning of each year), ensuring voters addresses are updated. A comprehensive overview of this

data is available in the Appendix.

The dataset includes details about each voter’s registration status (e.g., active, removed) and the reason for that status. It also highlights voter demographics such as race, gender, and age, as well as party affiliation and residential addresses spanning from 2005 to the present day. Each voter has a unique ID, allowing for the tracking of individual voters across different locations and years within the state. By leveraging the extensive geographic data attached to each voter, I convert every home address into corresponding census tract and block-group categories using Geographic Information System (GIS) analysis. This conversion maps each voter’s residence to various neighborhoods defined by either census tracts or block groups.

I compiled a migration record for each valid voter using the North Carolina Voter Registration data from 2009 to 2020. Every address has been geocoded and assigned to specific block groups. I track each voter’s annual movements—whether they move in, move out, or remain within a block group—based on changes in their recorded addresses. I calculate the number of inflows and outflows per year for each block group. The net population change within a block group at a specific time (t) is obtained by subtracting the outflows from the inflows during that period (t). My primary focus for migration metrics is on movements at the block group level, including population inflows, outflows, and net population changes. I perform analyses for all voters combined, as well as separately for white and Black voters.

In North Carolina, the legal age for voter registration is 18. Thus, I consider individuals aged 18 or 19 in the dataset as new registrants rather than newcomers to the city. Conversely, those above the age of 75 who disappear from the dataset are likely deceased, not those who have relocated. My analysis focuses on the subset of voters who have registration records spanning more than two years out of the 12 total, and are over 18 years old. I eliminated potential new registrants by excluding initial registrations for those under 20, and those likely deceased voters, by omitting the final registrations of those over 75. In my sample, 25% of the voters have been consistently registered for all 12 years, while 75% have kept their registration for over two years. In a robustness check, I introduced stricter criteria by excluding initial and final registration records for all age groups. The results remain consistent.

How representative is the voter registration data? I conducted a comparative analysis between the demographic information from voter registration records and the 2019-2020 census data for North Carolina at the tract level. To align with the age criteria used in the voter registration data, I limited the census data to individuals aged 20 to 75. Table 1 indicates that, on average, at the tract level, voter registration data reflects slightly higher representation for both Black and white populations, along with a higher female-to-male ratio.

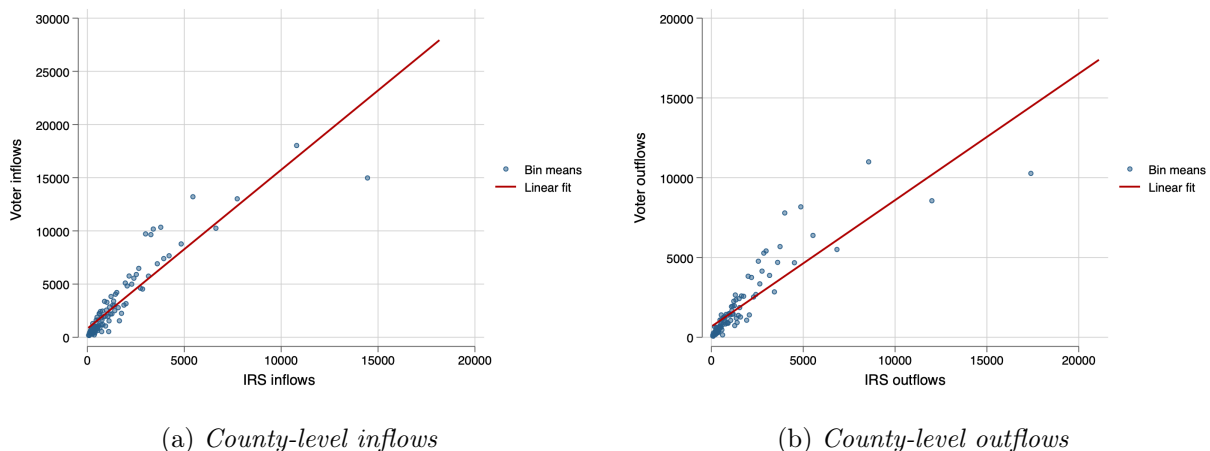
Table B.1 displays summary statistics from the North Carolina voter registration data, highlighting block-group level migrations between 2009 and 2020. On average, within a block group, 75% of all move-ins come from outside the city, and 64% are from outside the county. 69% of move-outs from a block group relocate beyond the city, and 54% leave the county.

To assess how well the Voter file captures migration more broadly, figure 1 contrasts the Internal Revenue Service (IRS) county-level migration statistics with the North Carolina voter county migration data, covering counties in my sample from 2012 to 2019. The IRS migration data tracks annual address changes from individual tax returns. The county-level inflow and outflow figures from my migration data correlate well with the IRS migration data, with correlation coefficients ranging from 0.8 to 1.5.

Table 1: *Summary statistics of tract-level demographics mean*

	NC census data	NC voter registration data	U.S. major cities census data
Total population	2825.919	2012.417	4193.500
Black share	0.229	0.241	0.258
White share	0.662	0.698	0.540
Others	0.130	0.110	0.201
Female/Male	1.072	1.221	1.080

Figure 1: *Cross-county migration data comparison—voter data v.s. IRS data*



3.1.2 Elections Data

The mayoral election data for North Carolina are sourced from official records available on the North Carolina State Board of Elections website. This data encompasses three main categories: election returns, candidate filings, and voter registration details ³.

The election returns data are essential for identifying specific instances and locations of closely

³There are few other states with easily accessible data on both elections and voters; North Carolina is also unique in that voter registration files are available for different points in time, not just the current snapshot of voters.

contested city council elections. These records include detailed information about each candidate, such as their names, the offices they contested, and their respective vote totals. For this analysis, I extract data on mayoral candidates for the period from 2009 to 2019.

The candidate-level data lacks personal details about the candidates, such as race, gender, or party affiliation. As such, I cannot directly use the election data to identify close elections between white and non-white candidates. To rectify this, I turn to voter registration files to provide the missing information. I match mayoral candidates from election returns with voter files using details like the candidate’s name and city. However, candidates with common names could match multiple individuals in the voter registration files within the designated city. When this happens, the candidate filings data is incorporated. This data records everyone running for public office in North Carolina each year, and includes their residential addresses. First, I match candidates by name and city from the candidate filing data to determine their addresses. Then, I pair the zip code data with the election returns, reducing the chance of multiple matches. I should mention that some candidates remain unmatched, possibly due to name discrepancies between the election return data and the voter files (e.g., “John Smith” vs. “J. Brady Smith” or “John B. Smith”). To address this, I manually collect unmatched candidates’ demographic details by examining various campaign websites⁴ and local government platforms. In elections where more than two candidates are running for mayor, I focus on the top two vote-getters in the final round, emphasizing the “marginal” candidates. Table 2 Panel A displays summary statistics of these candidates’ characteristics for my sample. Among all mayoral election candidates, 15.5% are Black, and 24.8% are female. Within Black candidates specifically, 58.9% are affiliated with the Democratic Party, 35.7% are non-partisan, and the remaining candidates are split between Republican and unaffiliated affiliations. Among white candidates, 22.8% are Democrats, 45.6% are non-partisan, and 10.9% are Republicans. In table B.2, I show the summary statistics of the candidates included in my final analysis sample, which is restricted to black and white candidates.

3.1.3 U.S. major cities sample

I collected election data related to mayoral races in the core cities of the 120 largest Metropolitan Statistical Areas (MSAs) from various campaign websites⁵. These websites offer election results as well as detailed information about candidates, including their names, gender, and political affiliation. While the racial and/or ethnic backgrounds of many candidates are available, there are instances where this data is missing. To address this, I collected data manually, determining racial backgrounds through photographs from local government websites and local newspaper coverage. Table 2 Panel B provides summary statistics on these candidates’ characteristics. Among all mayoral election candidates, 21% are Black, and 19.1% are female. Within Black candidates specifically, 76.1% are affiliated with the Democratic Party, 8.05% are republicans, and the remaining candidates are

⁴<https://www.ourcampaigns.com>; <https://ballotpedia.org>

⁵<https://www.ourcampaigns.com>; <https://ballotpedia.org>

split between Republican and others. Among white candidates, 47.43% are Democrats, 12.93% are non-partisan, and 29.73% are Republicans.

To estimate migration patterns for the 120 major U.S. cities, I use annual population statistics at the tract level from 2006 to 2019. This data is sourced from the U.S. Census Tract Population Data.⁶ To align with the North Carolina migration data, the sample includes only individuals aged between 20 and 75 years. Table 1 summarizes this tract-level demographic information.

Table 2: *Summary statistics of mayoral election candidates*

Panel A: North Carolina mayoral election candidates			
	Percent		Percent
Black share	15.5%	Democratic	43.9%
White share	82.6%	Republican	9.9%
Others	1.9%	Non Partisan	40.4%
Female share	24.8%	Unaffiliated	5.9%
Total #	1177		
Panel B: U.S. major cities mayoral election candidates			
	Percent		Percent
Black share	21.0%	Democratic	54.5%
White share	72.2%	Republican	24.2%
Others	6.8%	Non Partisan	20.8%
Female share	19.1%	Unaffiliated	0.6%
Total #	936		

3.1.4 Analysis data

The election dataset for North Carolina encompasses mayoral elections from 2009 to 2019 in which one of the two top candidates (either the winner or the first runner-up) was white and the other was Black. I identified 216 distinct contests in 122 different municipalities that met this criteria. Of these, 55 contests in 48 municipalities are “close” with a victory margin of less than ten percentage points. After merging the election data with the migration data, I’m left with a final count of 108 municipalities with 180 elections in total, and 39 municipalities with 46 elections for those contests decided by a margin of ten percentage points or fewer. For the 120 major cities in the U.S., the final election dataset covers mayoral elections from 1999 to 2019. It highlights cases where one of the top two candidates (either the winner or the primary runner-up) was white, and the other was Black. This criteria fits 177 unique elections in 70 different municipalities. Of these, 44 elections in 32 municipalities were “close”, defined as those with a victory margin of less than 10 percentage points. Table B.2 provides the summary statistics of mayoral election candidates in the final sample.

⁶<https://seer.cancer.gov/censustract-pops/>

When matching the election data with migration data, I form a panel around each election. For every election, I incorporate four years of migration data preceding the new mayor taking office and four years following. However, due to uncertainties regarding the exact time mayors assume their positions, and because of policy shifts in election years (McCrary, 2002; Baicker and Jacobson, 2007), I exclude migration data from the election years.

Regarding migration data, I compile individual location choices at the tract level, organizing tracts into three categories: majority-Black tracts, where Black residents outnumber any other racial group; diverse tracts, where the Black population makes up 30% to 50% of the total; and white tracts, where all racial groups, except whites, comprise less than 30% of the population. I use demographic percentages from the 2010 census tract as the foundation for neighborhood classifications. The main findings are presented at the tract level, specifically within the three aforementioned neighborhood classifications.

Table 3 presents the pre-election city-level demographics for cities with a Black mayor and those with a white mayor, among all the cities in my analysis sample. For the North Carolina sample, cities with Black mayors have a smaller total population than cities with white mayors, while the Black share in the former is slightly higher (36% compared to 32%). For the major U.S. cities, the total population and Black share are similar between cities with Black mayors and those with white mayors.

Table 3: *Pre-election city-level demographics*

Panel A: Pre-election demographics in North Carolina		
	Black mayor	White Mayor
Total population	290970.5	117759.3
Black population	103617.2	37132.9
Black share	36.5%	32.4%
# of cities	45	78
Panel B: Pre-election demographics in U.S. major cities		
	Black mayor	White Mayor
Total population	1360326.0	1473811.0
Black population	311065.2	375707.4
Black share	26.0%	26.0%
# of cities	45	47

3.1.5 Other datasets

In the mechanisms section, I use the Housing Price Index (HPI), Toxics Release Inventory (TRI) numbers, and public school enrollment data in North Carolina as indicators of neighborhood amenity levels. Additionally, I gather data from local newspapers and compile names of neighborhoods to

assess media attention directed towards Black communities.

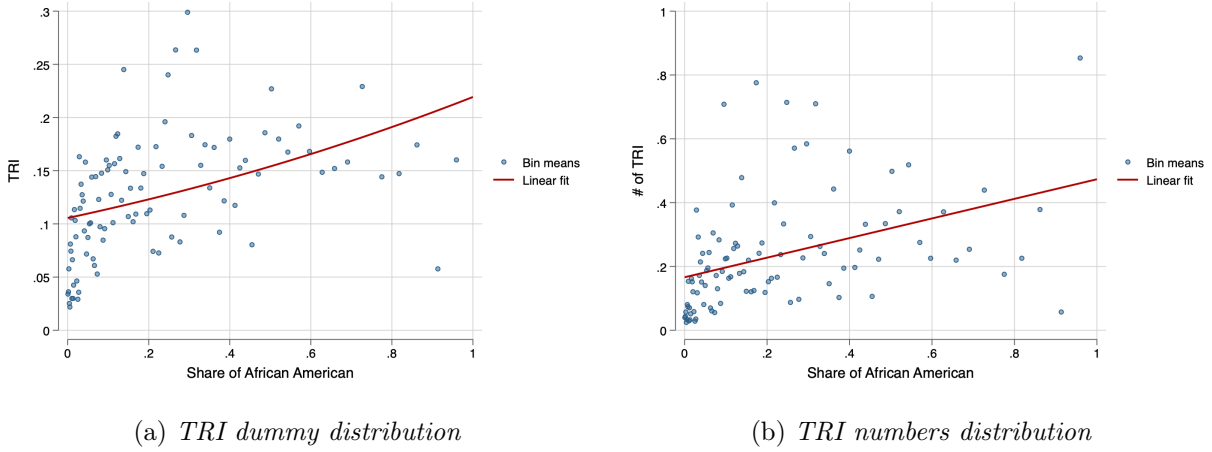
The housing price index data comes from the Federal Housing Finance Agency (FHFA). It is a comprehensive collection of publicly available house price indexes that measure changes in single-family home values. FHFA uses a fully transparent methodology based upon a weighted, repeat-sales statistical technique to analyze house price transaction data. I use the FHFA housing price index at the tract level from 2000 to 2018. I exclude housing prices in the bottom and top one percentiles of the distribution. Table B.4 presents summary statistics for all neighborhoods, as well as for neighborhoods with less than 30% Black share, diverse neighborhoods, and majority Black neighborhoods, respectively.

The Toxics Release Inventory (TRI) is a resource that monitors the management of specific toxic chemicals that could potentially harm human health and the environment. Annually, facilities across various U.S. industry sectors must report the amounts of these chemicals either released into the environment or managed through means like recycling, energy recovery, or treatment. This data is then compiled into the TRI. Typically, facilities reporting to TRI are large establishments in sectors such as manufacturing, metal mining, electric power generation, chemical production, and hazardous waste treatment. This data has been widely used as measures of pollution exposure for individuals and areas Banzhaf and Walsh (2008); Wang et al. (2021). Banzhaf and Walsh (2008) presents evidence suggesting that TRI facilities are linked to a deterioration in the socio-economic status of the community over time. I sourced the TRI data from the United States Environment Protection Agency’s website for this research. This data provides details such as each inventory site’s name, its geographical coordinates (longitude and latitude), and the total amount of chemicals released. I then created two metrics to measure the environmental quality of individual neighborhoods. The first is a binary variable that becomes 1 if a given block group has any TRI sites situated within it. As of 2015, 13% of the block groups reported the presence of TRI facilities in North Carolina. The second metric denotes the total count of Toxics Release Inventories within each block group. Figure 2 visualizes the spread of TRI in relation to the proportion of Black residents in neighborhoods. The representation indicates a discernible positive association between the presence of TRI and the percentage of Black residents in a neighborhood (0.105 for whether the neighborhood has TRIs and 0.3 for the count of TRIs in each neighborhood).

The data on public school enrollment is sourced from The Education Data Portal database. My sample encompasses 2,600 K12 public schools listed in the Common Core of Data, spanning from 2004 to 2019. Among these, 30% qualify as majority-Black schools based on the proportion of Black student enrollment, while 14% are situated in predominantly Black neighborhoods. Table B.5 provides a detailed overview of the demographic breakdown of school enrollments.

For the media coverage analysis, I concentrate on major U.S. cities due to the limited availability of digitized newspaper archives for North Carolina cities. I source the digital archives of local newspapers from two websites: newspaper.com and newsbank.com. By conducting a combined search across these databases, I collected any pages that mention both the name of a specific

Figure 2: *Toxic Release Inventories' distribution*



neighborhood and its associated city, in articles published between 2000 and 2019. I constructed two variables to measure the local coverage of each neighborhood. One represents the absolute number of pages that mention the neighborhood’s name. The other variable indicates the proportion of coverage each neighborhood receives relative to the total coverage all local neighborhoods garner.

I derived the names of these neighborhoods from boundary maps gathered by each city’s Planning and Development Department. Of the 39 cities that experienced close elections (defined as those with a vote-share margin $\leq 13\%$), I was able to obtain neighborhood names for 32. To determine the demographics of each neighborhood and identify those considered Black neighborhoods, I overlaid the neighborhood boundaries onto census block maps. Using this approach, I computed the proportion of Black residents in each neighborhood by calculating the ratio of the neighborhood area to the census block area, supplemented with block-level data on racial demographics. Table B.6 provides a detailed breakdown of neighborhood demographics and media coverage for the subset of data corresponding to close-election cities. Because the median proportion of Black residents in each neighborhood is 15.6%, I categorized neighborhoods with a Black population exceeding 30% as “Black neighborhoods” in my analysis. The results remain consistent when the categorization thresholds vary between 30% and 40%.

3.2 Methods

3.2.1 Baseline difference-in-difference specification

This paper adopts a difference-in-differences (DiD) methodology, paired with the intuition of a regression discontinuity approach. Due to the relatively low number of municipalities and elections in the final dataset, I use the canonical close-elections regression discontinuity design, which relies solely on post-election variation and fits lines to candidates’ margins of victory on either side of the victory threshold. This strategy ideally utilizes a substantial quantity of data points flanking the

cutoff to fit the lines accurately and pinpoint the discontinuity precisely at the cutoff. However, given our smaller number of observations around the cut-off, a difference-in-differences approach, comparing averages before and after an event, imposes less structure. As such, it is a better fit for scenarios in which there is a smaller number of observations on either side of the cutoff. While identification at the cutoff is lost, the aim of the difference-in-differences design instead is to account for any unobserved confounders via fixed effects.

I also construct a panel around each relevant election event, to take advantage of the ability to observe both the pre- and the post-election outcomes of each election. Therefore, the difference-in-differences setup compares changes in migration outcomes before vs. after an election between a white and Black candidate in municipalities where the Black candidate narrowly won (relative to cities where the Black candidate narrowly lost). The estimating Equation is:

$$\text{Migration Outcome}_{bct} = \beta_1(\text{Black Win}_{ct} \times \text{Post}_t) + \beta_2 \text{Post}_t + \theta_c + \text{neigh}_b + \tau_t \quad (1)$$

In the Equation, b indexes neighborhood, c elections, and t time periods (relative to the election year). $\text{Migration Outcome}_{bct}$ is migration outcome at neighborhood b , city c during period t . $1(\text{Black Win}_{ct})$ is an indicator variable equal to 1 if the Black mayor wins in election c . Post_t is the time dummy which indicates whether it is pre- or post- the election. θ_c and τ_t control the election-level fixed effect and year fixed effect. neigh_b controls for the neighborhood fixed effect. β_1 identifies the differential effect of a Black mayor's win on the outcome.

However, I still draw on the regression discontinuity intuition that outcomes in narrowly contested elections are more plausibly exogenous than they would be in the full range of contests. As such, while the estimating Equation is a difference-in-difference specification, I restrict attention to narrowly decided contests (with margins of victory of less than 10-15 percentage points).⁷ In my study, given that optimal bandwidths differ depending on the outcome variables and sample sizes, I start by determining the optimal bandwidths for three primary outcome variables—net population for all voters, net population for Black voters, and net population for white voters. I then average these three bandwidths to maintain consistency across various analyses and facilitate comparisons. Consequently, the bandwidth for the North Carolina sample stands at a 10% vote share margin, while for U.S. major cities, it is 13%. The estimation results are robust across multiple bandwidths ranging from 0.06 to 0.14. The estimation results are robust across multiple bandwidths. The main results are presented in the form of event study graphs in the subsequent section. These graphs show no signs of violating the parallel assumption required for a difference-in-difference design.

⁷Bandwidths of 10-15 percentage points were determined by collapsing the data to one observation per agency, measuring post vs. pre changes in the residualized outcomes (residualizing out the main set of fixed effects and controls used in our analysis). I then use the [Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik \(2014\)](#) method, positing a polynomial of degree zero (to match that our analysis does not fit lines to either side of the cutoff), to identify the optimal bandwidths.

3.2.2 Stacked difference-in-differences specification

Recent research has highlighted potential biases in two-way fixed effects difference-in-differences (TWFE-DID) estimates. These biases become particularly pronounced in situations that involve (1) staggered treatment implementations, as observed in this paper, and (2) variable dynamics of treatment effects, which should be expected in the context of the present study (Goodman-Bacon, 2021; Baker, Larcker, and Wang, 2022). The primary concern with the traditional TWFE-DID in staggered treatment scenarios is that units that have already been treated are used as references for those awaiting treatment. This approach can compromise the consistent trends assumption.

In my analysis, I utilize the “stacked” difference-in-differences method (Cengiz et al., 2019). This approach classifies units (in this case, cities) based on the year they begin the treatment, which I term as “treatment year groups” or simply “groups”. Within each group, I create data panels spanning four years before and four years after the treatment’s commencement. For instance, for a city that started mayoral elections in 2014, I generated a unique panel covering data from 2010 to 2018. This panel incorporates not only the city that began the treatment in 2014 but also control units — cities that had not experienced the treatment until at least after 2018. This method allows for a comparison between cities that began the treatment in a specific year and the appropriate control cities within a set period, providing a more refined analysis.

The panels are designed to prevent overlapping treatments in difference-in-difference (DID) configurations and are subsequently “stacked” to enable a comprehensive regression that amalgamates the effects discerned across all panels. This “stacked” configuration adopts a structure akin to the two-way fixed effects difference-in-difference (TWFE-DID) approach but further refines it by excluding observations under treatment (with a Black mayor) from the panels of White-win elections. Hence, the identification is derived from comparisons within each panel, ensuring that treated units are only juxtaposed with “clean” controls — those neither previously nor imminently treated.

3.2.3 Other concerns

While approximately 50% of the sample in North Carolina and 20% in major U.S. cities consists of non-partisan and unaffiliated candidates, it is essential to explore any correlation between the Black mayor effect and the influence of party affiliation. In Section 6.1, I explore this question using two approaches. First, I introduce another dummy variable, “*Dem win*”. This variable is set to 1 if the mayor is a Democrat and 0 otherwise. I then interact this variable with the time dummy “*post*” and integrate it into Equation 1. The revised Equation is as follows:

$$\text{Migration Outcome}_{bct} = \beta_1(\text{Black Win}_{ct} \times \text{Post}_t) + \beta_2(\text{Dem Win}_{ct} \times \text{Post}_t) + \beta_3 \text{Post}_t + \theta_c + \text{neigh}_b + \tau_t \quad (2)$$

If there is a strong correlation between the effect of having a Black mayor and the effect of having a Democratic mayor, the coefficient β_1 for $(\text{Black Win}_{ct}) * \text{Post}_t$ should become insignificant. Otherwise, this indicates that party affiliation is not the primary factor driving the Black mayor effect. As shown in Table 13, the results suggest that the Black mayor effect is not primarily attributable to differences in party affiliation.

Second, I estimate the impact of electing a Democratic mayor on racial sorting using the same empirical framework. Specifically, I replace Black Win_{ct} with Dem Win_{ct} in Equation (1). On average, electing a Democratic mayor has little effect on net population change at the city level and leads to a slight decline in net population in majority-Black neighborhoods.

4 Main results

4.1 Net population change

The effects of Black mayors on changes in net population at the tract level across different types of neighborhoods are presented in event study graphs. Figures 3 through 6⁸ alongside Table B.3 reveal that in North Carolina, electing Black mayors from close elections led to a net population increase of 3.9 percent in majority-Black neighborhoods, 1.2 percent in diverse neighborhoods, and 2.5 percent in neighborhoods with 30% less Black share. Specifically, Black mayors lead to an increase in the net population of both Black and white residents in majority-Black neighborhoods by nearly equal percentages (approximately 4%). While in diverse neighborhoods, they attracted slightly more Black residents (2%) than white ones (1%). In neighborhoods with 30% less Black shares (also referred to as white neighborhoods), interestingly, despite a lower baseline Black population⁹, there was a pronounced 6% increase in Black residents compared to a 1.7% rise in white residents. The corresponding table is reported in the appendix as B.3.

Citywide, table 4 shows that over one-third of the net population growth across all neighborhood types is driven by individuals relocating from other cities. Both majority-Black and white neighborhoods experience demographic increases due to these cross-city moves. The effect is particularly pronounced in majority-Black neighborhoods, where 45% of the net population gain comes from inter-city migration, with Black residents accounting for 48% of those movers.

However, understanding the net changes in population distribution across different racial groups in various neighborhoods does not provide the complete picture. While majority-Black neighborhoods saw increases in both Black and white populations, it remains unclear what underlies this trend. Is it due to gentrification, with affluent white and Black residents moving in and displacement of existing residents? Or perhaps it is due to reduced outflows, indicating that existing residents are

⁸The average number of voters (all voters, African American voters, and white voters) at the tract level is indicated in parentheses

⁹The average number of Black voters in white tracts is 171.

choosing to remain? The subsequent migration decomposition will shed light on these dynamics.

Figure 3: *Net population change in all tracts (North Carolina)*

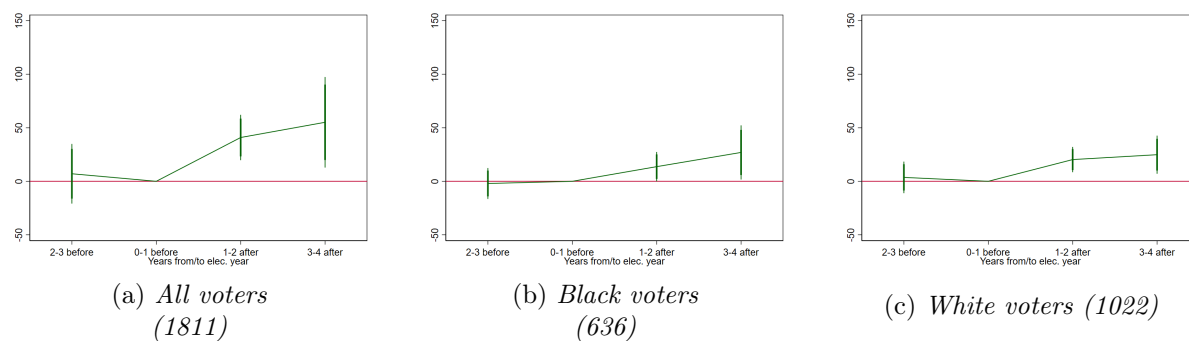


Figure 4: *Net population change in majority-black tracts (North Carolina)*

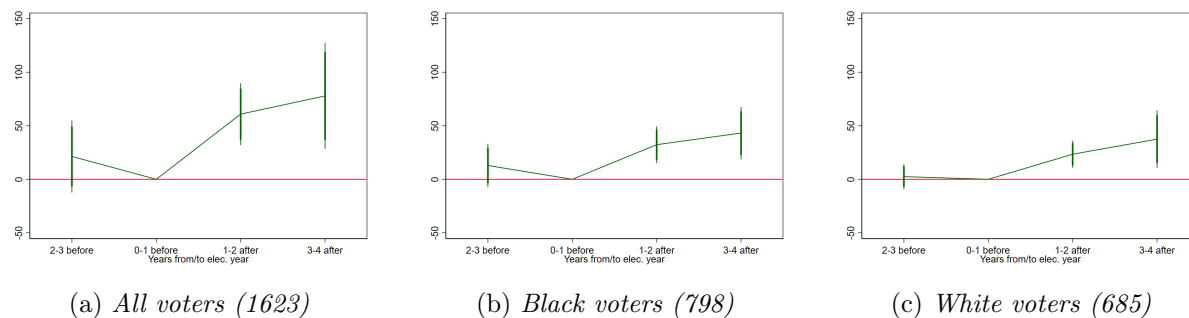


Figure 5: *Net population change in 30%-50% black tracts (North Carolina)*

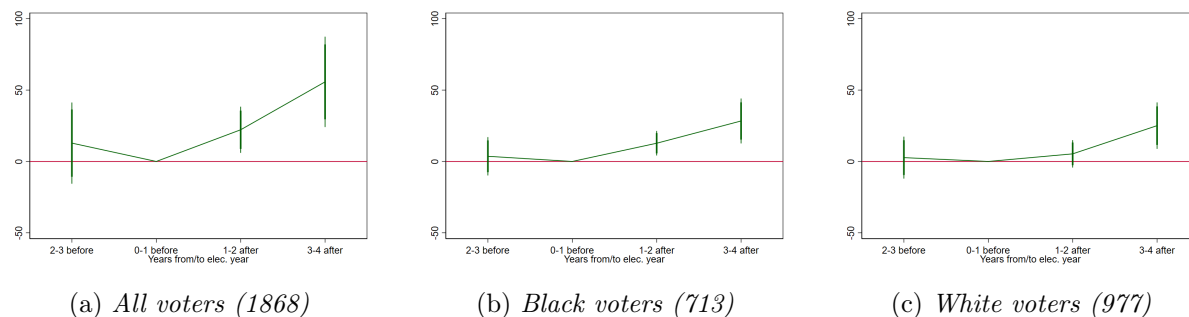


Figure 6: *Net population change in 30% less black tracts (North Carolina)*

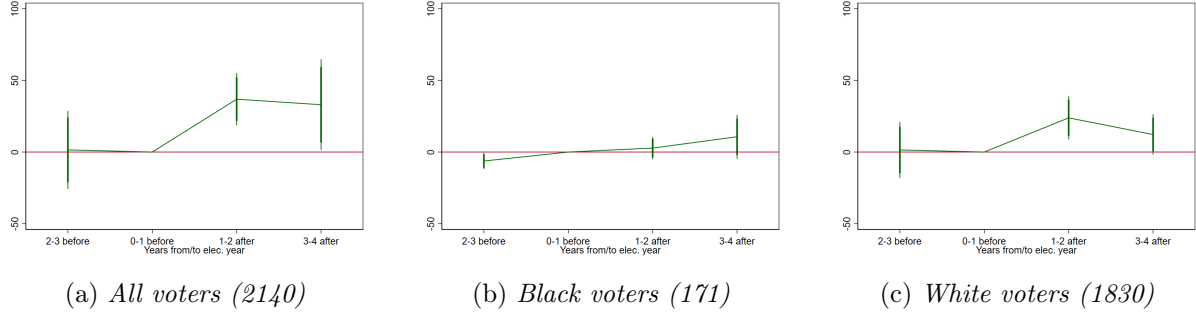


Table 4: *Across-city net population change outcomes*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	19.02*** (3.817)	7.208*** (2.297)	8.434*** (2.610)	28.81*** (3.930)	13.71*** (2.878)	9.884*** (1.315)
Mean	1811	636	1022	1623	798	685
Close election #	44	44	44	26	26	26
Observations	4087	4087	4087	1411	1411	1411
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	8.028** (3.343)	2.764 (2.222)	3.236 (2.395)	16.15*** (5.222)	2.826 (2.170)	10.52** (4.215)
Mean	1868	713	977	2140	171	1830
Close election #	30	30	30	28	28	28
Observations	698	698	698	1849	1849	1849
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

4.2 Decomposing net population change

In this section, I use individual-level migration records to examine the origins and destinations of each mover. This allows me to decompose the net population change in each neighborhood into migration inflows and outflows. Examining these inflows and outflows provides valuable insights into the nature of demographic changes and offers direct evidence of a Black mayor’s effect on

Black flight—an understanding that cannot be achieved solely through aggregate-level data. Table 5 presents results for three distinct neighborhood types. Having a Black mayor results in more residents choosing to remain in their neighborhoods, with this effect being most pronounced in majority-Black and diverse neighborhoods. The surge in population in majority-Black neighborhoods is largely attributed to a reduction in outflows of both Black (5.5%) and white residents (4%). For diverse neighborhoods, the population growth is predominantly due to a 1.3% decline in the outflows of Black residents. In neighborhoods with less than 30% Black residents, there is a noticeable 1.1% uptick in the inflow of white residents along with decreased outflows from both the Black (5.3%) and white populations (0.6%).

Citywide, Table A.2 shows that the election of a Black mayor primarily increases retention of both Black and white residents within the city—by 0.4% to 0.9%—rather than attracting new in-migration. In majority-Black neighborhoods, a reduction in across-city out-migration accounts for 27% of the total decline in move-outs. In neighborhoods with less than 30% Black, across-city out-migration accounts for 43% of the overall reduction.

When combined with the insights from Table 5, the overall results indicate that net population growth is primarily driven by a decrease in out-migration. Based on revealed residential preferences, the presence of a Black mayor predominantly benefits those who originally resided in their neighborhoods, with the impact being more substantial for majority-Black neighborhoods. Notably, in majority-Black neighborhoods, the reduced outflows occur among both Black and white residents. This suggests the potential implementation of place-based interventions under the leadership of Black mayors, benefiting existing residents across all groups.

Table 5: *Move-in Move-out outcomes*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All voters	Move-in African American	White	All voters	Move out African American	White
Panel A: All tracts						
Post*Blackwin	26.12** (11.02)	6.381 (4.742)	12.58** (5.725)	-41.66*** (14.63)	-23.08*** (7.902)	-15.16*** (4.339)
Mean	1811	636	1022	1811	636	1022
Close election #	45	45	45	44	44	44
Observations	4328	4328	4328	4328	4328	4328
Panel B: Majority-Black tracts						
Post*Blackwin	21.07 (12.87)	11.78 (9.086)	3.651 (3.494)	-81.10*** (18.60)	-44.08*** (11.22)	-26.76*** (5.540)
Mean	1623	798	685	1623	798	685
Close election #	26	26	26	26	26	26
Observations	1507	1507	1507	1507	1507	1507
Panel C: 30%-50% black tracts						
Post*Blackwin	21.27* (10.94)	9.179 (7.031)	7.842 (4.701)	-8.812 (11.14)	-6.476 (6.168)	-4.377 (5.200)
Mean	1868	713	977	1868	713	977
Close election #	30	30	30	30	30	30
Observations	738	738	738	738	738	738
Panel C: 30% less tracts						
Post*Blackwin	33.54** (13.62)	0.706 (3.188)	20.75** (8.401)	-20.71* (12.00)	-9.204* (4.471)	-11.75** (5.345)
Mean	2140	171	1830	2140	171	1830
Close election #	29	29	29	29	29	29
Observations	1945	1945	1945	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

4.3 Replication with national data

In this section, I extend the net population change analysis to a broader sample of 120 major U.S. cities. This is to ascertain whether the patterns identified in North Carolina are consistent with

other major U.S. cities. The results, represented in Figures 7 through 10¹⁰ and detailed in table A.3, depict the population shifts following the election of a Black mayor in closely contested elections across various neighborhoods in these major cities. On average, there is a rise of approximately 2.3% in the total population across all neighborhoods. This surge is predominantly attributed to population growth in majority-Black and white neighborhoods. In majority-Black neighborhoods, this growth is primarily attributed to an influx of Black residents by 6.5%. White neighborhoods witness a significant increase in both Black (6%) and white residents (3.4%). These trends from major U.S. cities largely align with those observed in North Carolina, with a notable exception: in North Carolina cities, majority-Black neighborhoods see a similar influx of both white and Black residents.

The findings from the major U.S. cities predominantly indicate that Black mayors tend to draw more Black individuals to majority-Black neighborhoods, and more white individuals to white neighborhoods, hinting at a potential increase in segregation. In the following section, I will investigate the shifts in the composition of various racial groups, as well as the broader city-level segregation dynamics after having a Black mayor.

Figure 7: *Net population change in All voters tracts (U.S. major cities)*

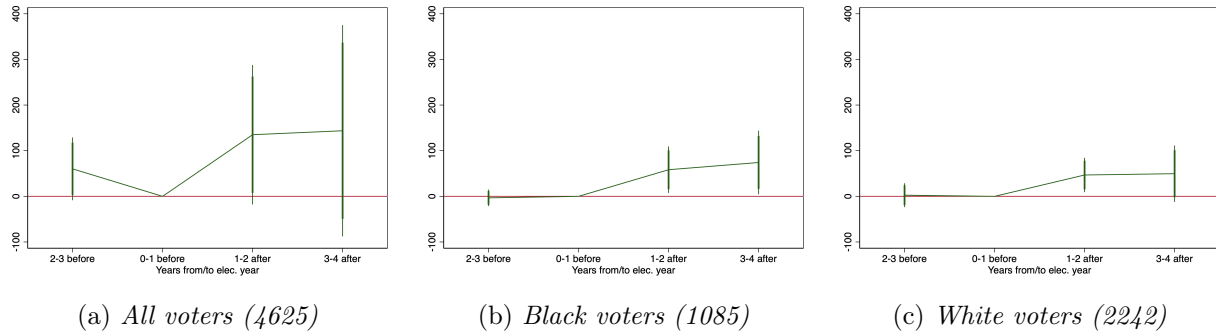
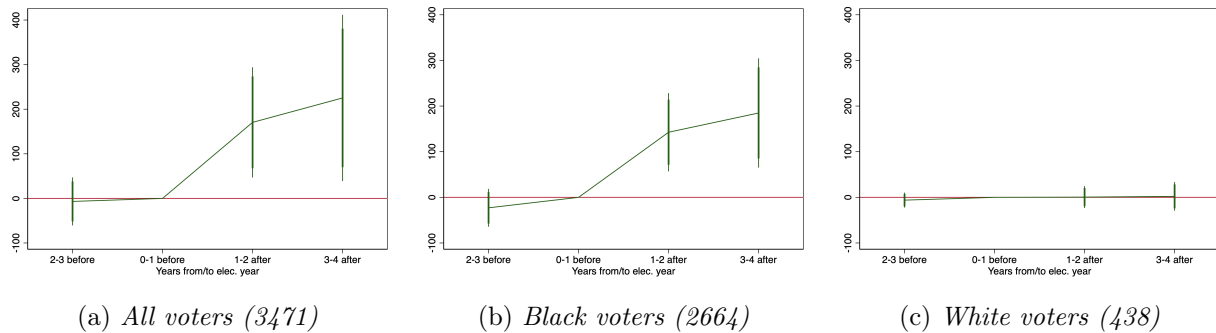


Figure 8: *Net population change in majority black neighborhoods (U.S. major cities)*



¹⁰The average number of population (total population, African American population, and white population) at the tract level is indicated in parentheses

Figure 9: *Net population change in 30%-50% black neighborhoods (U.S. major cities)*

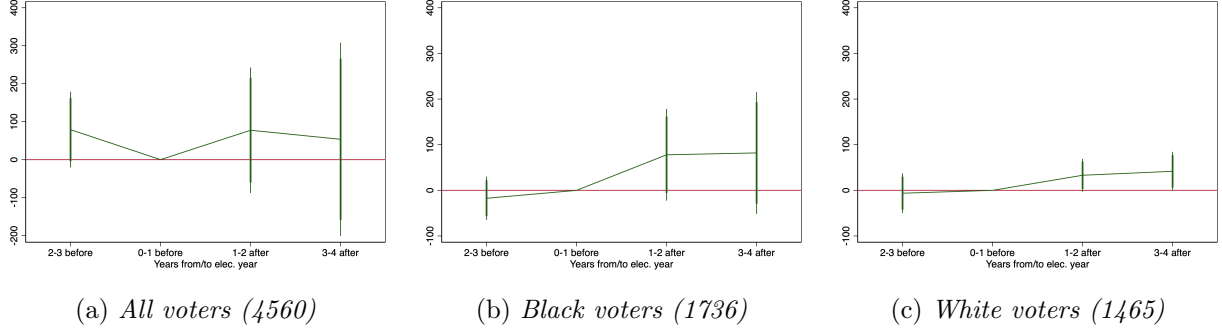
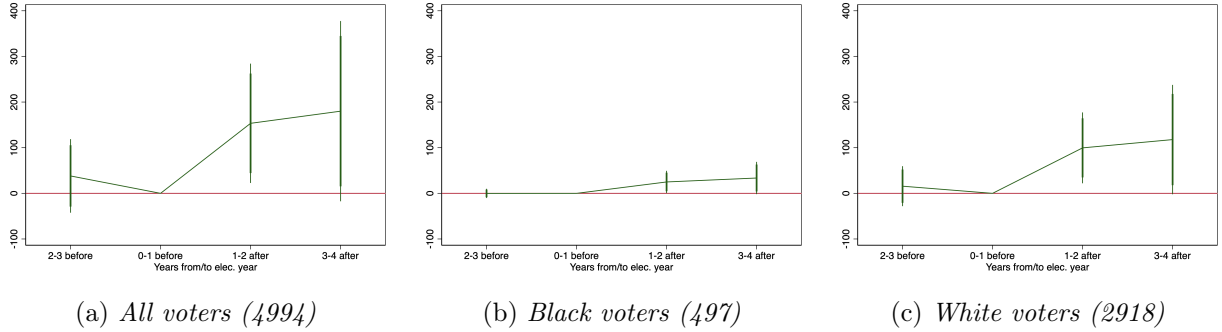


Figure 10: *Net population change in 30% less black neighborhoods (U.S. major cities)*



4.4 Segregation

Since 2000, major U.S. metro areas have seen a modest but steady decline in residential Black–White segregation, decreasing by approximately 17.8% by 2020. ¹¹

Table 6 presents the changes in city-level segregation and the proportion of Black residents following the election of a Black mayor in a closely contested race. I employ the dissimilarity index as the metric for city-level segregation. ¹² Columns 1 and 2 present results from North Carolina,

¹¹Black–White dissimilarity index fell from about 64.0 in 2000 to roughly 59.0 in 2010 and 52.8 by 2020 among the largest metros

¹²The dissimilarity index quantifies the percentage of a group’s population that would need to relocate in every neighborhood to reflect the same percentage of that group as the entire metropolitan area. The index varies from 0.0 (complete integration) to 1.0 (complete segregation). The basic formula for the index of dissimilarity is:

$$D = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^N \left| \frac{a_i}{A} - \frac{b_i}{B} \right|$$

where:

- a_i = the population of Group A in area i (e.g., census tract i),
- A = the total population of Group A in the larger geographic unit for which the index is being calculated (e.g., the city),
- b_i = the population of Group B in area i ,
- B = the total population of Group B in the larger geographic unit.

while Columns 3 and 4 report findings from major U.S. cities. In both samples, electing a Black mayor in a close election is associated with a 1% to 1.7% increase in the dissimilarity index and a 1.3% to 2.8% rise in the Black population share over the four-year term.

Furthermore, Table 7 details the impact of a Black mayor on shifts in racial composition across majority-Black neighborhoods, diverse neighborhoods, and predominantly white neighborhoods. As shown in Table 7, the rise in a city’s Black demographic is largely driven by an increased Black population share in majority-Black neighborhoods. These findings are consistent with the theoretical and empirical results of Bayer, Fang, and McMillan (2014) and Banzhaf and Walsh (2013), which suggest that place-based interventions expanding public goods provisions in lower-amenity minority communities can lead to heightened group segregation. In other words, majority-Black neighborhoods retain a disproportionately large number of Black residents who choose to stay rather than move elsewhere (e.g., to suburban areas).

These observable changes in locational preferences and segregation patterns hint at place-based investment happening under Black mayoral leadership. In the next section, I examine these potential mechanisms by evaluating shifts in amenity distribution and changes in media coverage following the election of a Black mayor.

Table 6: *Segregation*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	North Carolina		US major cities	
	Segregation index	Black share	Segregation index	Black share
PostXBlackwin	0.00493* (0.00291)	0.00566* (0.00311)	0.0104*** (0.00349)	0.00785** (0.00347)
Mean	0.52	0.39	0.57	0.27
Close election #	46	46	52	52
Observations	4328	4328	65206	65101
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

In this context, Group A refers to the white population, and Group B refers to the Black population. The index D measures the level of residential segregation between Black and white populations at the city level.

Table 7: *Black share across neighborhoods*

	(1)	(3)	(2)	(4)
Panel A: North Carolina	Black share			
	All	50% more	30-50%	30% less
PostXBlackwin	0.00566* (0.00311)	0.0129*** (0.00349)	0.00586 (0.00589)	0.00280 (0.00483)
Mean	0.39	0.68	0.39	0.13
Close election #	46	26	30	29
Observations	4328	1507	738	1945
Panel B: US major cities	All	50% more	30-50%	30% less
PostXBlackwin	0.00785** (0.00347)	0.0145*** (0.00525)	0.0181** (0.00889)	0.00204 (0.00171)
Mean	0.27	0.73	0.36	0.09
Close election #	52	51	51	52
Observations	65101	15702	4983	28292
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

5 Mechanisms and future implications

How might Black mayors shape residents' decisions to remain in the city, particularly in majority-Black neighborhoods? If the decline in the urban Black population is largely attributable to differences in amenities between Black urban neighborhoods, can the reduced out-migration patterns observed be explained by changes in the quality of amenities across neighborhoods? Additionally, can Black mayors address amenity disparities between Black and white neighborhoods by reallocating resources and investing more in the former?

To explore these questions, I use two proxies for neighborhood-level amenities: housing price indexes and pollution exposure. Beyond resource reallocation, Black mayors may also increase public attention to Black neighborhoods through local media. To evaluate this, I measure public attention allocation using local newspaper coverage of various neighborhoods.

5.1 Housing price index

House prices have long been used in the literature as a sufficient statistic for valuing public and private investments (Chay and Greenstone, 2005; Turner, Haughwout, and Van Der Klaauw, 2014; Beach et al., 2018). In this section, I use the FHFA House Price Index ¹³ as a proxy for localized amenities to explore how the Black mayor influences amenity qualities in Black neighborhoods. I exclude the housing prices in the bottom and top one percentiles of the distribution. The outcome variable is the log of the housing price index after controlling for the city-specific time trend. Table 8 shows that electing a Black mayor leads to a 4% increase in housing prices in the city. Compared to white neighborhoods, majority Black neighborhoods experience a significantly higher increase in housing prices. These findings align with those in Beach et al. (2018), which showed that the election of a nonwhite city-level councilmember reduces the pre-existing gaps in housing prices between minority and non-minority neighborhoods.

Table 8: *Housing price index*

	(1)	(2)
	log(HPI)	log(HPI)
PostXBlackwin	0.0407*** (0.0107)	0.0223** (0.00978)
PostXBlackwinXDiverse		0.00547 (0.00634)
PostXBlackwinXMajorBlack		0.0361** (0.0142)
Close election #	39	39
Observations	5654	5654
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes

Notes: Sample restricted to narrow elections (less than 10% vote share margin). Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 for the baseline group - white neighborhoods. Post*BlackwinXDiverse indicates a differential impact on neighborhoods with 30-50% Black share. Post*BlackwinXmajorBlack indicates a differential impact on majority-Black neighborhoods. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

¹³The FHFA House Price Index is a comprehensive collection of publicly available house price indexes that measure changes in single-family home values. FHFA uses a fully transparent methodology based upon a weighted, repeat-sales statistical technique to analyze house price transaction data.

5.2 The reallocation of locally unwanted land use

Air pollution significantly affects neighborhood quality, and individual residential choices are heavily shaped by exposure to pollution (Bayer et al., 2016; Banzhaf and Walsh, 2008). It is well-documented that low-income communities and communities of color face disproportionately high levels of pollution. In the economic literature, these environmental disparities are often linked to household sorting patterns (Banzhaf and Walsh, 2008; Gamper-Rabindran and Timmins, 2011; Depro, Timmins, and O’Neil, 2015; Hausman and Stolper, 2021).

Mayors can help determine pollution levels in neighborhoods by implementing zoning policies and enforcing conditional use permits with specific pollution limits, thereby regulating the location and operations of polluting firms and holding businesses accountable for their environmental impact.

In this section, I measure pollution exposure in each neighborhood using the EPA’s Toxics Release Inventory (TRI). Column 1 of Table 9 indicates that electing a Black mayor from a close election does not significantly affect the presence of TRI sites in a neighborhood. In contrast, Columns 2 and 3 show that having a Black mayor significantly narrows the disparity in the number of TRI sites between majority-Black and white neighborhoods. Column 2 specifically reports estimates for neighborhoods that already contain TRI sites. These findings highlight the role of local governments in reallocating resources across communities and reducing environmental inequities among diverse groups.

Although the existing literature on government interventions to address environmental inequities has focused primarily on Clean Air Act (CAA) amendments (Currie and Walker, 2019; Sager and Singer, 2022), pollution information disclosures (Wang et al., 2021; Banzhaf and Walsh, 2008), and various federal initiatives (Haninger, Ma, and Timmins, 2017), this study offers insights into how local political processes can influence environmental injustice on a neighborhood scale.

Table 9: *Toxics Release Inventories outcomes*

	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Extensive TRI	Intensive TRI	Aggregated TRI
PostXBlackwin	-0.00172 (0.00575)	0.207*** (0.0688)	0.194** (0.0833)
PostXBlackwinXMajorBlack	-0.00433 (0.00949)	-0.164** (0.0783)	-0.183* (0.0998)
Mean	0.14	2.39	0.33
Close elections #	44	30	44
Method	OLS	Poisson	Poisson
Observations	13023	1781	13023
FE: Block group	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Sample restricted to narrow elections (less than 10% vote share margin). Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 for the baseline group - white neighborhoods. Post*BlackwinXMajorBlack indicates a differential impact on majority-Black neighborhoods. In column 1, the outcome variable is a dummy indicating whether each neighborhood has TRIs or not. Ordinary least squares regression is applied. In columns 2 and 3, the outcome variable is the number of TRI at each neighborhood, and the Poisson pseudo-likelihood regression with multiple levels of fixed effects is used due to the distribution of TRI count in my sample. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

5.3 The reallocation of media attention

Local media holds a significant position in fostering neighborhood development. It serves as a spotlight, drawing attention to a range of issues specific to individual neighborhoods, spanning from infrastructure deficiencies to educational requisites. By spotlighting these issues, the media holds the potential to galvanize action, urging local authorities and policymakers to respond and rectify these challenges. Furthermore, local media provides a forum for community members to express their thoughts, grievances, and aspirations for their locale, ensuring that a more diverse array of viewpoints is incorporated in the decision-making frameworks (Milan, 2009).

In addition to reallocating amenity resources, Black mayors have the potential to redirect public attention towards Black neighborhoods, shedding light on their issues through public discussion. To investigate this further, I collect local newspaper coverage data for major U.S. cities spanning from 2000 to 2019, and the neighborhood-level boundary and name data for these cities. I compare white neighborhoods with non-white neighborhoods where the Black share is greater than 30%¹⁴. Columns

¹⁴Due to the limited sample size in the media coverage data, fewer majority-Black neighborhoods are observed in cities with close elections (fewer than 20), making estimation in those areas underpowered. Therefore, I compare white neighborhoods with neighborhoods with at least 30% Black share.

1-3 in table 10 show that the names of Black neighborhoods are mentioned more frequently in local newspapers after the election of a Black mayor in intensive and extensive margin. I include the total coverage of all neighborhoods in each city as a control variable. Having a Black mayor diminishes the disparity in media coverage between Black and white neighborhoods by 15%. Column 4 shows that electing a Black mayor elevates the media coverage percentage for Black neighborhoods by 0.039 standard deviations.

Table 10: *Local media coverage*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Extensive Cov	Intensive Cov	Aggregated Cov	Share of Cov
Post x Blackwin	-0.0702** (0.0290)	-0.116 (0.0800)	-0.137* (0.0820)	0.000130 (0.000377)
Post x Blackwin x Blackneigh	0.0810* (0.0392)	0.113** (0.0510)	0.155*** (0.0486)	0.00113* (0.000621)
Mean	0.8	652.8	557.3	0.01
# of Local news	Yes	Yes	Yes	
Close elections #	34	33	34	34
Observation	28808	23234	27212	27893
FE: Neighborhood	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Sample restricted to narrow elections (less than 13% vote share margin). Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 for the baseline group - white neighborhoods. Post*BlackwinXBlackneigh indicates a differential impact on Black neighborhoods, specifically those where the Black population exceeds 30%. In Column 1, In column 1, the outcome variable is a dummy indicating whether each neighborhood is covered in the local newspaper or not. Poisson pseudo-likelihood regression is used with multiple levels of fixed effects due to the distribution of coverage in my sample. In columns 2 and 3, the outcome variable is the frequency of each neighborhood's name being covered in the local newspaper. In column, 4 the outcome variable is the share of local media coverage for each neighborhood among all the local news. Ordinary least squares regression is applied. I standardize the outcome variable (share of coverage), to better interpret the results. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * $< .1$, ** $< .05$, *** $< .01$.

5.4 Further analysis

5.4.1 Public school enrollment

In this section, I investigate the influence of Black leadership on public school enrollments, with a focus on students and schools situated in predominantly Black neighborhoods. Although the local governments are not directly involved in the public schools' finances (this is the responsibility of the school board), public school enrollment is a mechanical result following the neighborhoods' population change.

Schools are classified based on their geographical locations into three categories: those in white neighborhoods, those in diverse neighborhoods, and those in predominantly Black neighborhoods. Table 11 illustrates that electing a Black mayor leads to a rise in Black student enrollment in schools located in majority-Black neighborhoods. This trend can be attributed in part to an increase in Black families staying in these neighborhoods, boosting the enrollment of Black students. As the school district sees an influx of Black families, the school board composition may diversify.

Table 11: *Public school enrollment*

	(1) All	(2) African American	(3) White
Post*Blackwin	24.88** (10.29)	1.043 (5.044)	6.023 (5.883)
Post*BlackwinXDiverse	35.01*** (12.62)	6.492 (9.437)	2.368 (5.648)
Post*BlackwinXMajorBlack	34.25* (19.46)	31.95** (11.83)	-4.052 (5.281)
Mean	657.8	281.4	211.7
Close elections #	44	44	44
Observations	6166	6166	6166
FE: School	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 for the baseline group - white neighborhoods. Post*BlackwinXmajorBlack indicates a differential impact on majority-Black neighborhoods. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Sample restricted to narrow elections (less than 10% vote share margin). Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

5.4.2 Crime

Neighborhood safety is also one of the main amenities that determine residents' location choices (Bayer et al., 2016). In U.S. municipalities, oversight of police agencies is ultimately exercised by city councils and mayors' offices. In this study, I utilize data from the Federal Bureau of Investigation's Uniform Crime Reports to examine the effect of Black mayors on the arrests made by local police departments and on the reported city-level crime rates. Table 12 shows no significant impact on the number of arrests across all groups and the proportion of arrests involving Black individuals, nor any impact on the reported crime rate.

Table 12: *Crimes reported and arrests*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	All	Total arrests per African American	100 capita white	Black share	Crime reported per 100 capita All
PostXBlackwin	-0.0433 (0.0842)	-0.0588 (0.0486)	-0.0336 (0.0359)	0.00253 (0.0178)	-0.107 (0.147)
Mean	3	2	1	0.6	4.7
Observations	202	202	202	202	278
Close election #	35	35	35	35	43
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Sample restricted to narrow elections (less than 10% vote share margin). Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

6 Robustness tests

6.1 The effect of party affiliation compared to the Black mayor impact

In mayoral elections between Black and white candidates in North Carolina, 14.8% are contests between Republican and Democratic candidates. Given this, I explore if there is a correlation between the Black mayor effect and the democratic mayor effect using two approaches. First, I incorporate an interaction between the party affiliation dummy and the election time dummy into Equation 1. As presented in table 13, even after including the interaction term $Post * demwin$, the coefficients for $Post * Blackwin$ remain significant with a similar magnitude to table B.3 across all specifications. Most of the party coefficients are negative and insignificant, except for the white population in majority-Black neighborhoods and the Black population in diverse neighborhoods. The findings above indicate that the effects of having a Black mayor can largely account for the migration patterns in most of the scenarios presented. While a mayor's party affiliation might influence racial distribution, it is not the primary factor shaping these outcomes.

Table 13: *Results with party controls*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Post*Blackwin	60.48*** (17.34)	22.04*** (7.349)	26.41*** (8.566)	72.34*** (24.88)	47.04** (18.58)	17.59*** (3.648)
Post*Demwin	-13.44 (18.66)	-0.984 (7.810)	-0.774 (11.39)	-11.86 (25.65)	-14.90 (18.84)	15.35*** (3.819)
Mean	1811	636	1022	1623	798	685
Close election #	45	45	45	26	26	26
Observations	4328	4328	4328	1507	1507	1507
Panel B	30-50% Black neighborhoods			30% less Black neighborhoods		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Post*Blackwin	40.60*** (13.39)	23.01*** (4.477)	14.35 (8.819)	59.05*** (12.27)	7.934 (5.920)	30.26*** (9.464)
Post*Demwin	-23.66 (14.69)	-12.28** (4.672)	-6.442 (8.951)	-9.408 (15.82)	3.570 (6.418)	1.365 (15.16)
Mean	1868	713	977	2140	171	1830
Close election #	30	30	30	29	29	29
Observations	738	738	738	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Sample restricted to narrow elections (less than 10% vote share margin). Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 2. Post*demwin represents the coefficient β_2 in Equation 2. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

Second, I estimate the impact of electing a Democratic mayor on racial sorting by replacing Black Win_{ct} with Dem Win_{ct} in Equation (1), where Dem Win_{ct} is an indicator variable equal to 1 if a Democratic candidate wins election in contests between Democratic and non-Democratic candidates.

Table 14 presents the results. On average, electing a Democratic mayor has little effect on the net population change in the city. In neighborhoods with at least 30% Black residents¹⁵, the net populations of both Black and White groups decline by approximately 0.5% to 1.9% following the election—an effect opposite in direction to that of electing a Black mayor.

¹⁵Fewer than 20 such elections between Democratic and non-Democratic candidates occurred in cities with majority-Black neighborhoods, making estimation in those areas underpowered. Therefore, I focus on neighborhoods with a Black population share of 30% or more.

Table 14: *Party affiliation and racial sorting*

	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Net population change		
Panel A	All tracts		
	All voters	African American	White
Post*Demwin	1.847 (10.03)	-6.119 (6.236)	8.236 (8.786)
Mean	1811	636	1022
Close election #	45	45	45
Observations	4328	4328	4328
Panel B	30% more Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White
Post*Demwin	-31.66*** (3.948)	-13.61*** (1.593)	-5.299*** (1.044)
Mean	1868	713	977
Close election #	30	30	30
Observations	738	738	738
Panel B	30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White
Post*Demwin	9.186 (7.484)	-0.0734 (4.320)	6.158 (6.682)
Mean	1868	713	977
Close election #	30	30	30
Observations	738	738	738
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The sample is restricted to close elections (defined as having a margin of less than 10 percentage points). The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

6.2 A stricter migration standard

To prevent confusion between new registrations and migration inflows, as well as deceased registrations and migration outflows, applied a more rigorous standard to the migration data by omitting all initial and final registration entries to replicate the analysis for net population change. ¹⁶ Table 15 showcases the primary findings from this revised migration dataset. The results remain consis-

¹⁶In the main results above, I exclude initial registrations for individuals under age 20 and final registrations for those over age 75.

tent with B.3, with an approximately 20%¹⁷ reduction in magnitude. By leaving out all initial and final registration records, I eliminate not only potential new registrants and deceased voters, but also potential inter-state migrants. Since first-time registrations could also be from individuals relocating to North Carolina from other states. The similarity between these findings and the main results reinforces the robustness of the identification.

Table 15: *Results with the stricter migration standard*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	39.34*** (6.878)	13.40*** (3.511)	18.83*** (4.573)	48.30*** (9.358)	26.22*** (5.874)	15.92*** (2.869)
Mean	1811	636	1022	1623	798	685
Close election #	39	39	39	22	22	22
Observations	4328	4328	4328	1507	1507	1507
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	20.89*** (6.115)	10.39** (3.935)	8.883** (3.379)	40.31*** (7.606)	4.272 (3.633)	24.15*** (6.192)
Mean	1868	713	977	2140	171	1830
Close election #	26	26	26	24	24	24
Observations	738	738	738	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. The sample is restricted to narrow elections (less than 10% vote share margin). Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

6.3 Excluding re-elected Black mayor

In the set of mayoral elections contested between Black and white candidates, 10% have a Black incumbent who gets re-elected for a subsequent term. These cities have experienced Black leadership for over four years, potentially leading to dynamics differing from those of cities transitioning from a white to a Black mayor. In this section, I leave out the re-elected Black mayors and center my analysis on cities undergoing a racial shift in leadership from white to Black. Table 16 showcases

¹⁷For the overall net population change across all tracts, the primary results in Section 4 have a coefficient of 58.5. In comparison, the coefficient from this new sample is $(58.5-47.12)/58.5 = 19.4\%$

the net population data from this refined sample. The results resemble the initial findings, though most of the coefficients are of a reduced magnitude. Notably, there is a significant reduction in the coefficients for net population change in predominantly Black neighborhoods. For example, the overall net population change effect drops from 74.13 to 55.16. One plausible interpretation is that the influence of a Black mayor is magnified in cities that have successive terms under Black leadership, or in cities where a Black mayor gets re-elected.

Table 16: *Net population change without reelected Black mayors*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	43.77*** (12.72)	18.08*** (4.638)	21.41** (8.049)	51.32** (21.48)	32.95 (19.62)	17.99*** (4.042)
Mean	1811	636	1022	1623	798	685
Close election #	43	43	43	24	24	24
Observations	2504	2504	2504	727	727	727
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	25.72*** (8.567)	15.69*** (4.981)	9.543 (6.765)	47.28*** (11.59)	7.008* (3.999)	28.93** (11.73)
Mean	1868	713	977	2140	171	1830
Close election #	28	28	28	27	27	27
Observations	498	498	498	1225	1225	1225
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. The sample is restricted to narrow elections (less than 10% vote share margin). Significance levels are indicated by * $< .1$, ** $< .05$, *** $< .01$.

6.4 Multiple bandwidths checks

I estimate the effect of having a Black mayor on primary migration outcomes across several bandwidths, spanning from 0.6 to 0.14. Figures B.1 through B.3 display the pertinent coefficient for three core outcome variables: total net population change, net Black population change, and net white population change, across all neighborhoods in North Carolina. For every outcome variable,

the coefficients consistently exhibit significance and maintain a similar scale. ¹⁸

7 Conclusion

Historically Black neighborhoods in urban areas have suffered from a loss of vitality, leading to a sense of hopelessness and diminishing prospects for improvement. The impact of having Black officials on majority-Black neighborhoods, and the well-being of their constituents remains an open question. Does having a Black leader help reduce racial disparities through fairer public policies and counteract the trend of Black flight? How does minority representation in local government influence the city and affect residents of all racial groups? This paper examines the influence of Black representation in local government on individual migration decisions both within and between cities, as well as on residential segregation using individual-level migration data constructed from the voter registration files in North Carolina.

My findings indicate that in cities across North Carolina, the election of Black mayors in close races has led to a net population increase in both majority-Black and non-majority-Black neighborhoods. Black mayors have attracted roughly equal proportions of Black and white residents to majority-Black neighborhoods, with each group increasing by about 4%. In white neighborhoods, there is a notable 6% increase in Black residents, compared to a 1.7% rise in white residents. When expanding the analysis to include 120 major U.S. cities, the patterns observed in North Carolina largely align with those found in these larger cities.

A deeper analysis of migration decomposition reveals that the average net population growth is primarily driven by a reduction in outflows. In majority-Black neighborhoods, the population increases primarily due to reduced outflows among Black and white residents, declining by 5.5% and 4%, respectively. In neighborhoods with fewer than 30% Black residents, growth is driven by a 1.1% increase in white in-migration, combined with reductions in out-migration among both groups. These patterns suggest that the election of a Black mayor primarily benefits existing residents—especially in majority-Black neighborhoods—by encouraging them to stay, pointing toward place-based rather than group-targeted investments as the primary driver of change.

From a compositional perspective, the net effect of these changes is an increase in racial segregation, driven by the growing concentration of Black individuals in predominantly Black neighborhoods. Further investigation into the underlying factors shows that Black representation reduces the amenity disparities between majority-Black and white neighborhoods, while also shifting local media attention to these areas. The evidence suggests that Black representation promotes more equitable resource distribution to majority-Black neighborhoods, reduces the rate of Black out-migration, and enhances the city’s overall attractiveness.

¹⁸The coefficient at a bandwidth of 0.6 appears smaller than the rest, possibly due to the limited number of closely contested elections, which total 29 in this case.

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A Appendix

A.1 Corresponding tables for event study graphs and across-city migration patterns

Table A.1: *Net population change in North Carolina*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	50.97*** (7.206)	21.34*** (4.608)	25.86*** (4.547)	63.49*** (9.525)	35.91*** (6.324)	29.05*** (4.367)
Mean	1811	636	1022	1623	798	685
Close election #	45	45	45	26	26	26
Observations	4328	4328	4328	1507	1507	1507
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	24.08*** (5.620)	14.43*** (2.962)	9.854** (3.567)	52.87*** (6.995)	10.28* (5.410)	31.15*** (7.252)
Mean	1868	713	977	2140	171	1830
Close election #	30	30	30	29	29	29
Observations	738	738	738	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

Table A.2: *Across-city move-in move-out outcomes*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	All voters	Move-in African American	White	All voters	Move out African American	White
Panel A: All tracts						
Post*Blackwin	4.049 (3.119)	0.199 (1.327)	3.100 (2.218)	-12.49*** (2.318)	-5.758*** (1.301)	-4.225*** (1.142)
Mean	1811	636	1022	1811	636	1022
Close election #	45	45	45	44	44	44
Observations	4328	4328	4328	4328	4328	4328
Panel B: Majority-Black tracts						
Post*Blackwin	-0.938 (3.181)	-1.127 (1.957)	-0.442 (1.069)	-21.85*** (2.639)	-10.42*** (1.559)	-7.118*** (0.917)
Mean	1623	798	685	1623	798	685
Close election #	26	26	26	26	26	26
Observations	1507	1507	1507	1507	1507	1507
Panel C: 30%-50% black tracts						
Post*Blackwin	6.430* (3.217)	3.004 (1.774)	1.896 (1.881)	-1.322 (2.723)	-1.441 (1.333)	0.671 (1.768)
Mean	1868	713	977	1868	713	977
Close election #	30	30	30	30	30	30
Observations	738	738	738	738	738	738
Panel C: 30% less tracts						
Post*Blackwin	6.506 (4.109)	0.382 (1.461)	5.275 (3.221)	-9.072*** (2.496)	-2.504** (0.951)	-5.197** (1.892)
Mean	2140	171	1830	2140	171	1830
Close election #	29	29	29	28	28	28
Observations	1945	1945	1945	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

Table A.3: *Net population change in major US. cities*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Post*Blackwin	106.8 (112.2)	67.33** (30.15)	46.75 (29.02)	199.2** (81.03)	173.9*** (50.36)	4.134 (14.72)
Mean	4625	1086	2242	3471	2665	439
Close election #	52	52	52	51	51	51
oObservations	65206	65206	65206	15766	15766	15766
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Post*Blackwin	24.11 (125.7)	89.03 (59.82)	40.35 (26.48)	144.8 (94.75)	28.91* (15.24)	99.23* (57.66)
Mean	4560	1736	1465	4994	498	2919
Close election #	51	51	51	52	52	52
Observations	4983	4983	4983	28322	28322	28322
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

B Online Appendix (not intended for publication)

B.1 Summary statistics

Table B.1: *Summary statistics of migration inflows and outflows in North Carolina*

	Obs	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max	Share of total inflows/outflows
Blockgroup inflows	89,375	58.814	79.16	0	2355	1.000
City inflows	89,375	44.499	64.17	0	2329	0.757
County inflows	89,375	37.902	56.18	0	2323	0.644
Blockgroup outflows	81,688	45.079	53.10	0	3112	1.000
City outflows	81,688	30.940	38.90	0	1990	0.686
County inflows	81,688	24.378	32.20	0	1869	0.541

Table B.2: *Summary Statistics of Mayoral election candidates for final sample*

Panel A: North Carolina mayor candidates characteristics (final sample)			
	Percent		Percent
Black share	50.0%	Democratic	44.41
White share	50.0%	Republican	11.47
Female share	26.9%	Non Partisan	38.82
Total #	432	Unaffiliated	5.29
Panel B: U.S. major cities mayor candidates characteristics (final sample)			
	Percent		Percent
Black share	50.0%	Democratic	65.49%
White share	50.0%	Republican	17.3%
Female share	19.5%	Non Partisan	1.6%
Total #	452.0%	Unaffiliated	0.9%

B.2 Corresponding tables for event study graphs and across-city migration patterns

Table B.3: *Net population change in North Carolina*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	50.97*** (7.206)	21.34*** (4.608)	25.86*** (4.547)	63.49*** (9.525)	35.91*** (6.324)	29.05*** (4.367)
Mean	1811	636	1022	1623	798	685
Close election #	45	45	45	26	26	26
Observations	4328	4328	4328	1507	1507	1507
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	24.08*** (5.620)	14.43*** (2.962)	9.854** (3.567)	52.87*** (6.995)	10.28* (5.410)	31.15*** (7.252)
Mean	1868	713	977	2140	171	1830
Close election #	30	30	30	29	29	29
Observations	738	738	738	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Post*Blackwin represents the coefficient β_1 in Equation 1. The “Mean” row reports the average number of voters per tract, including totals for all voters, African American voters, and white voters. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are indicated by * < .1, ** < .05, *** < .01.

Table B.4: *Summary Statistics of Housing Price Index*

Neighborhoods (tracts)	Obs	Mean	Std. dev.	Min	Max
All	42,137	168.0813	64.10188	59.4	778.95
Black share $\leq 30\%$	32,163	174.6233	66.86476	71.87	778.95
Black share <50%, >30%	5,555	151.8465	44.32873	60.77	513.07
Black share $\geq 50\%$	4,026	137.6455	49.07256	59.4	478.88

Table B.5: *Summary Statistics of Public school enrollment*

North Carolina K12 Public school enrollment	
	Percent
Black share	28.2%
White share	51.1%
Others	20.6%
Female	52.8%

Table B.6: *Summary Statistics of local news and neighborhood demographics*

	Obs	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
Population	52,488	6873.293	15746.11	0.0002741	216437.3
Black share	52,488	0.2776021	0.2587979	0	0.9856255
Media coverage	52,488	656.8309	1788.87	0	37730

Figure B.1: *Tract-level net population change coefficient*

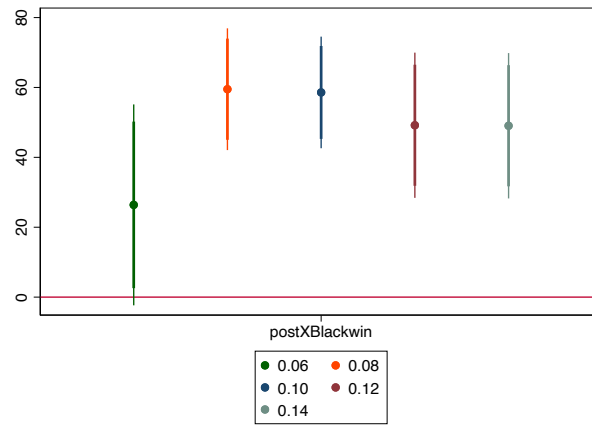
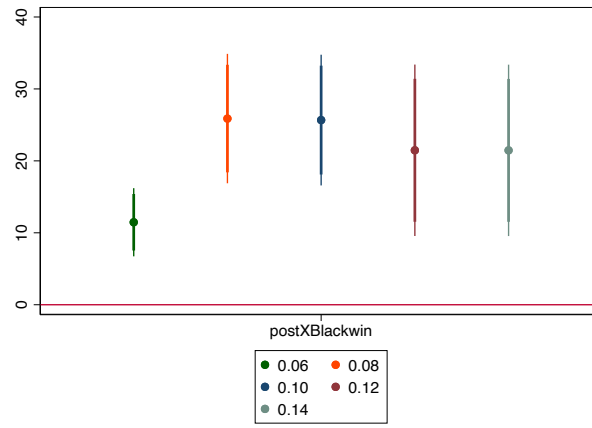
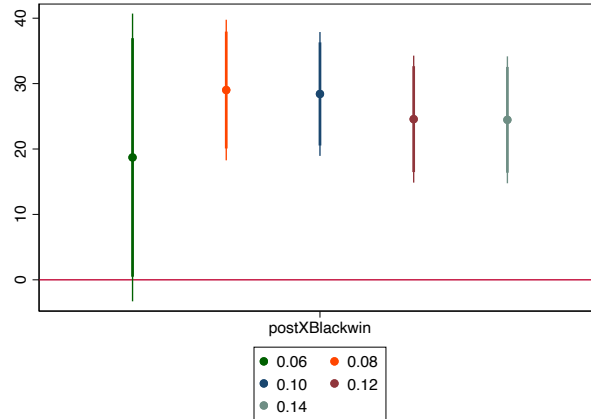


Figure B.2: *Tract-level net Black population change coefficient*



B.3 Multiple bandwidths

Figure B.3: *Tract-level net white population change coefficient*



B.4 The institution background of voter registration data in North Carolina

North Carolina has a high voter registration rate. As of January 9, 2021, there were 7,186,435 registered voters in North Carolina, accounting for 67% of the state’s total population.

To register as a voter in North Carolina, several qualifications need to be met. Firstly, one must be a U.S. citizen, though it is worth noting that specific citizenship documents are not required during registration. Potential voters can refer to the USCIS website for more details on citizenship. Secondly, an individual must reside in the county where they are registering and must have lived there for at least 30 days before the election. While these rules apply to most, there are special provisions under the federal Uniformed and Overseas Citizens Absentee Voting Act (UOCAVA). This act grants special rights to active duty military members, their families, and U.S. citizens living abroad, offering them a streamlined process to register and vote via mail-in ballots. Age is also a determining factor; one must be 18 years or older on the date of the general election. However, North Carolina does permit 16- and 17-year-olds to preregister. Moreover, 17-year-olds are allowed to vote in primary elections if they will turn 18 by the general election. Finally, those currently serving a felony sentence, which includes probation, post-release supervision, or parole, are ineligible to register.

Voter registration snapshot files provide up-to-date details for active voters, inactive voters, and voters removed within the past decade in North Carolina. They also include those who have tried to register or have unfinished registration steps. If a voter’s last voting date is over 10 years before the snapshot, they are excluded from these files, which are refreshed every Saturday. Post-election, finalizing voter registration might take several days across all counties. Voters are not removed from records for not voting. Instead, a biennial list maintenance process, as per federal and state laws, determines removals. After two federal election cycles without contact, voters receive a confirmation mailing, which they must return within 30 days. Failure to do so, or if the mail is undelivered, marks them as inactive. Although inactive voters remain registered, they need to confirm their address

when voting. After another two federal election cycles without contact, they are removed from the rolls, necessitating re-registration. This process aligns with N.C.G.S § 163-82.14.